Haechan Kim

Ph.D. candidate at Graduate School of AI, Korea Advanced Institute of Science and Technology (KAIST)

kim.haechan@kaist.ac.kr
Seoul, South Korea
Google Scholar
LinkedIn
X
GitHub

EDUCATION

B.S. in School of Computing (Certificate in AI)
Korea Advanced Institute of Science and Technology (KAIST)
MAR. 2018 - FEB. 2025

B.S. in School of Electrical Engineering
Korea Advanced Institute of Science and Technology (KAIST)
MAR. 2018 - FEB. 2025

Ph.D. in Kim Jaechul Graduate School of AI
Korea Advanced Institute of Science and Technology (KAIST)
MAR. 2025 - PRESENT

About Me

I am a Ph.D. candidate at Machine Learning and Intelligence Lab (MLILAB) in Korea Advanced Institute of Science and Technology (KAIST), advised by Prof.Eunho Yang.

My research broadly focuses on large language models, with particular interests in reinforcement learning with verifiable rewards and agentic reinforcement learning.

Publications

WHALE: A Simple Recipe for Joint Harness-Weight Optimization

Haechan Kim, Yoonho Lee, Gisang Lee, Chelsea Finn, Kangwook Lee

Preprint

Paper · Code · Tech Blog

Pruning and Distilling Mixture-of-Experts into Dense Language Models

Junhyuck Kim, Jihun Yun, **Haechan Kim**, Gyeongman Kim, Joonghyun Bae, Jaewoong Cho

Conference on Neural Information Processing Systems (NeurIPS), 2026 (oral)

Paper

KVoiceBench, KOpenAudioBench, and KMMAU: Agent-Driven Korean Speech Benchmarks for Evaluating SpeechLMs

Haechan Kim, Seungjun Chung, Inkyu Park, Jihoo Lee, Jonghyun Lee

Conference on Empirical Methods in Natural Language Processing (EMNLP), 2026 (findings)

Paper · Code · KVoiceBench · KOpenAudioBench · KMMAU

Raon-Speech Technical Report

Beomsoo Kim, Changho Choi, Dohyun Kim, Dongki Lee, Ethan Ewer, Eunchong Kim, Gyeongman Kim, **Haechan Kim**, Hyeonghwan Kim, Inkyu Park, Jihun Yun, Jihwan Moon, Jiyun Kim, Joonghyun Bae, Junhyuck Kim, Minkyu Kim, Sehun Lee, Seungjun Chung, Sungwoo Cho, Dongmin Park, Dongwon Kim, Hara Kang, Jonghyun Lee, Keon Lee, Kangwook Lee, Jaewoong Cho

Preprint

Paper · Raon-Speech-9B · Raon-SpeechChat-9B

Discounted Beta-Bernoulli Reward Estimation for Sample-Efficient Reinforcement Learning with Verifiable Rewards

Haechan Kim, Soohyun Ryu, Gyouk Chu, Doohyuk Jang, Eunho Yang

International Conference on Machine Learning (ICML), 2026

Paper

LearnerVoice A Dataset of Non-Native English Learners' Spontaneous Speech

Haechan Kim, Junho Myung, Seoyoung Kim, Sungpah Lee, Dongyeop Kang, Juho Kim

Annual Conference of the International Speech Communication Association (INTERSPEECH), 2024, Shortlisted for ISCA Best Student Paper Award 2024

Paper

Work Experiences

KRAFTON

Nov. 2025 - Aug. 2026

AI Research Div. · Research Intern · Seoul, South Korea

Advisor: Kangwook Lee

I developed Raon-Speech-9B and Raon-SpeechChat-9B, contributing especially to model probing and evaluation. I also conducted research on agentic reinforcement learning and harnesses, and investigated MoE merging and pruning methods.

KAIST Interaction Lab

Mar. 2023 - Mar. 2024

Visiting Researcher · Daejeon, South Korea

Advisor: Juho Kim

I published a paper titled 「*LearnerVoice: A Dataset of Non-Native English Learners' Spontaneous Speech*」, accepted to INTERSPEECH 2024. Additionally, I filed two patents: *"System for Learning English Speaking and Method Thereof"* and *"System for Diagnosing and Learning Pronunciation and Method Thereof"*.

Ringle

Jul. 2022 - Mar. 2024

Research Engineer · Seoul, South Korea

I spearheaded the planning, development, and deployment of an AI-driven engine, CAF, which predicts IELTS and TOEFL speaking scores by analyzing conversations between tutors and learners.

Projects

A.X K1: Unifying Non-thinking and Thinking Modes

KRAFTON developed A.X K1 to integrate Non-thinking and Thinking modes into a single model, enabling either fast responses or deeper reasoning through a mode-specific chat template. We explored multiple data recipes and found paired training on the same prompts effective for making the model follow the think token rather than surface-level prompt cues. This recipe was incorporated into A.X K1 training.

Paper · Tech Blog